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Disaster Recovery Test Summary

Every year Asana undertakes a Disaster Recovery Exercise. The goal of this exercise is to model a worst case scenario where our infrastructure is completely lost and we are forced to bring up data from backup snapshots of our production environment, which we call snapshots. This exercise was most recently completed on October 19, 2023.

This document gives a high level overview of the process and how corrections were applied to prepare for the next time we test our disaster recovery plan.

Asana's infrastructure consists of multiple databases that together deliver the product, so we need to restore multiple databases in order to successfully run this exercise. For each disaster recovery exercise we pick a sample of databases. These include the set of databases that contain global metadata, as well as the set of databases that contain customer data.

Process

1. Pick two databases that contain customer data. One of these databases includes Asana's domain so we can test the recovery portion fully.
2. Specific database snapshots are chosen that will be used as a restore point.
3. Launch base infrastructure in our backup region
 - a. Launch databases that were built from the snapshots
 - b. Launch test servers and applications
 - c. Set up the network infrastructure to be able to access version
4. Identify staleness in tooling and launch scripts and fix these cases
5. Test usage of the application and ensure all the data is correctly accessible

Results

We were able to successfully launch the two databases from the snapshots. We tested that the Asana app was functional, and the data was correctly restored from the backups.

Throughout the exercise there were some learnings, below is a summary of what we uncovered and fixed:

- We continued to migrate the management of our internal network and infrastructure resources over to a new system. This required minor updates to our recovery tooling.
- There was a process consolidation in how we launched a few services. This did not affect the recovery.

- The process of releasing new code to the clients was streamlined. This did not affect the recovery.